

“To download CyanogenMod, you don't need to root your device”



Abhisek Devkhota, senior engineering manager, CyanogenMod

CyanogenMod has formally entered the Indian market in partnership with Yureka, a brand from the house of Micromax. Gone are the days when CM, as CyanogenMod is fondly known as, was a tool for techies. The developers at CM want to clarify that the operating system has grown a lot since being a bedroom Android hack. It can be used by non-techies too. **Diksha P Gupta** from the *Open Source For You* team caught up with **Abhisek Devkhota, senior engineering manager, CyanogenMod**, at the launch of Yureka's Yu smartphone and discovered how CM is evolving, particularly in India. Excerpts:

Q Is there a need to have an OS like CyanogenMod when we already have Android?

Yes, you have Android but it is based on the concept of 'one size fits all'. Those flavours of Android available from different OEMs are always heavy. They offer no scope for self-expression. Look at the cell phone cases market, for instance. Whether it is about movie stars or sports, the back of the phone allows users to express themselves. Why not allow that in the software itself? It lets us, as developers, do what we want on our devices. After all, you invest a lot on a cell phone so not being able to do what you want on it is not that great an idea. What CyanogenMod does is, it allows users to do what they want on their devices.

Q This is a great concept but is it not only a techie's cup of tea? Typical users would not think of modifying their devices in the way CM allows. So, why should a non-techie, who has limited knowledge about OSS, go in for a CM-powered device?

Internationally, CM already has about 20 million users, and we have reached this figure by reaching out to enthusiasts who are usually the first buyers of a new technology. It is these people who make the buying decision for the house and influence the circle of people they are close to. However, we do understand that overly customised devices can be difficult to handle for many users. For them, it is just a CM device, like the Yu phone, which works awesomely, just out-of-the-box. So to an average user who doesn't care about the customisation aspects and the freedom allowed by the software, it is a great phone at a really good price point, with which there are updates and two-year support. But we would like to believe that once people use the product for a while, they would appreciate its capabilities and will spread the word amongst friends and family. That's how it's worked for us for about six years within the open source community. It is a good model to work with, and it has been successful for us ever since we started.